DEBATER GUIDE TO CAREERS

Achieve your academic and career goals – in your own mentally stimulating way

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter to Debaters

Debaters have a nearly unlimited appreciation for theoretical riddles. If there's no easy answer and the topic grabs them, Debaters can spend ages trying to find a solution. People with this personality type can sometimes struggle to explain their thoughts to others. Their theories are sometimes so complex that they aren't easily accessible to the average thinker, no matter how clear the explanation. Debaters may move on to another topic before their coworkers, partners, professors, or fellow students have sorted out the exact meaning of their words.

People with this personality type use their minds in a deliberate way, which is especially noticeable in their professional environment. They enjoy brainstorming and outlining all the choices. Nonconformists, they love challenging existing rules and routines, which makes them irreplaceable when it comes to improving existing systems and coming up with new, original plans. This tendency is invaluable for creating notable improvements under the right conditions – but it also may cause tension in the workplace. Not everybody is comfortable with shaking up an established system.

Similarly, Debaters are easily bored with routine work or rote studies full of memorization. Their minds are more like playgrounds than factories. They would much rather tackle difficult theoretical problems than trudge through well-established material, even if following the routine might be more productive.

Learning to express all these aspects of their personality in successful and fulfilling ways is a lifelong process for Debaters, just like anyone else. Areas as consequential as work and school provide important feedback that can make that process both exciting and challenging. There's much to be gained as Debaters explore – and push – their own potential and the limits of the world around them. Of course, there's always room for these vigorous, elastic-minded personalities to improve. When their growth is backed by desire, Debaters have a tremendous capacity not only to prosper on their own path but also to uncover hidden potentials in partnership with others. It's often just a matter of maintaining an open mind and cheerful optimism.

Want to boost your understanding of the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? Learn more here.

Academic Path

Few types are as adept at picking up on complex concepts as Debaters are – which is both a blessing and a curse for these inquisitive and, at times, argumentative types. Academia can be a wonderland of exploration and intrigue, but endless curiosity can also cause issues for this precocious personality type. Classes may seem too structured, preventing them from following their ever-evolving tangents. Many teachers bristle when they're inevitably criticized, questioned, or downright ignored by Debater students. Whatever dynamics might arise in the classroom, however, Debaters are hardwired to learn, so they go out of their way to create the education they truly desire.

To maximize their academic outcomes, Debaters can explore some of the opportunities and obstacles they might face throughout their academic careers. The following paragraphs will discuss how they learn when they're at their best, as well as what challenges they may face if they struggle to rein in some of their less-than-helpful behaviors. Additionally, we'll discuss how Debaters can influence their academic paths through high school and beyond with intentional actions and reflections.

How Debaters Learn

Adept at expansive thought, Debater students possess a wealth of intellectual curiosity, which gives them a good chance of enjoying their schooling. That said, they may experience significant tension with their instructors, as highly structured learning environments pose challenges for these independent-minded – and verbose – types.

Fortunately, if frustration doesn't turn into arrogance, Debaters' love of learning and discovery can sustain them throughout their academic careers. Education can represent an opportunity for them to pursue their passions, as well as develop the skills required to respectfully collaborate with others and see the value that others bring to the table – skills that can serve them for the rest of their lives, even if they don't realize it at the time.

Balanced Learning Habits

Capable Minds

Debaters are unlikely to follow social conventions that they believe are fundamentally irrational; regardless, they are often delightfully charming in their interactions with others. Generally, their desire to be knowledgeable is just as strong as their desire to be well-liked. When they can align the two in healthy ways, Debaters can engage with peers and teachers alike in entertaining yet elucidative conversations.

Their often-adversarial view of study can at times frustrate parents or teachers who see their incessant "why" questioning as defiance rather than sophisticated curiosity. However, educators who are up to the challenge of matching wits with Debater students find that nothing is more intellectually rewarding than dialogue with these loyal opponents whose ultimate interests are to enlighten, not humiliate.

A Rising Tide Lifts All Boats

At their best, Debaters challenge those around them to pursue ever-increasing levels of knowledge and accomplishment. Their gregariousness is as alluring as the proverbial flame, drawing in people who want to improve their ability to absorb and relate information in the seemingly effortless way Debaters do. Following in the footsteps of the great teacher and philosopher Socrates, their mentorship often revolves around hearty discussions that challenge preconceived notions and refuse to entertain willful ignorance.

In an educational setting, Debaters' tendency to fearlessly – and frequently – ask questions inspires their more timid peers, and it also encourages teachers and professors to elaborate on topics for

the benefit of everyone involved. Classrooms that contain curious, respectful Debaters are some of the liveliest, most engaging learning environments for both themselves and their peers.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Lacking Consideration

With their wealth of intellectual resources, Debaters can use their talents for the betterment of their lives, the lives of those around them, and even people they'll never meet. However, if they're unable to overcome personal frustrations with the perceived ineptitude and short-sightedness plaguing the bulk of humanity, they may decide that others aren't worth their time and choose to expend their energies with little regard for the consequences to others.

Debaters who believe in their superior intellectual prowess typically struggle to appreciate the different perspectives offered by those they deem less intelligent. They may have little patience for teachers and peers alike because they believe that their own knowledge and experience supersede whatever information anyone else provides – especially when the input of others contradicts what they believe is more logical. Rejecting other viewpoints is dangerous because it prevents Debaters from challenging their own possibly irrational beliefs, and it precludes them from experiencing the wealth of knowledge that's available only when they're open to other points of view.

Always Right – No Matter What!

Some Debaters struggle mightily with their need to be right. When their identity is too wrapped up in appearing smart and capable, they can't afford to be wrong: Giving an incorrect answer makes them feel incompetent or unintelligent. Consequently, when their confidence and ego come into play, Debaters put every ounce of brainpower into arguing for their answers or discrediting the answers of others. Although this can be incredibly frustrating for those on the receiving end of a Debater argument, it's important to remember that the overconfidence they attempt to display often belies a lack of personal confidence.

Confidence is a worthy quality, but without compassion to keep it in check, it can easily turn to arrogance. In their educational pursuits, Debaters may find themselves overly confident in their knowledge, to the point where they skimp out on the work necessary to properly complete projects or assignments. Reading a book on astrophysics certainly increases their understanding of the topic, but it by no means makes them experts, even though they may feel that way. Cutting corners, making assumptions, and putting in as little effort as possible are all potential hazards when Debaters believe they always know what is right.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Considering Other Ideas

When learning, Debaters may disregard others' opinions for any number of reasons; for instance, because they deem the other person less intelligent. However, it's important to understand that the best way to learn is to understand different perspectives – ironically, refusing to consider the viewpoints of supposedly ignorant people leads to more ignorance. When people with this personality type open themselves to new views, no matter how illogical or unrealistic they may seem, they also open themselves up to a greater wealth of knowledge.

Debaters' desire to figure out the world from a purely logical perspective can be a little rough on those around them. Others may not learn best by the same direct, hard, rational processes. Consequently, in group environments, Debaters may feel – and cause – friction.

To simultaneously address both problems, they can practice taking on another person's idea with the intention of seeing it from the other person's perspective *and* finding value in an idea they wouldn't have previously considered. This goes beyond just playing devil's advocate – taking on another viewpoint as though they believe and want to further it is much different from using it to merely argue a point. Debaters can practice sincerely considering someone else's idea by engaging in the following exercise:

- Take an idea that's intriguing but may be difficult to accept at face value, such as an alternative political viewpoint.

- Interview a friend, coworker, or family member who holds the view. Ask questions: "What about this idea do you find interesting?" "What is your reasoning for supporting this idea?" "How does this idea align with your personal beliefs?" Use the opportunity to determine why the idea is important and what reasons the person has for accepting it.

- Now consider the reasons the idea has been difficult to personally accept. Was information previously unknown or unavailable? Did the idea seem illogical or impractical, even though it may not be? Is it possible that the idea contradicts other ideas or beliefs that are personally important?

- It's not necessary to accept or support the idea that's being considered. Just listening to the reasons others support it and questioning your own preconceived notions are vitally important to remaining (or becoming) open-minded and objective.

Understanding the different ways other people exchange and process information fosters cooperation and expands Debaters' abilities by leaps and bounds. The benefit of developing cooperative skills can prove enormously valuable to Debaters in their educational careers, in work, and in life.

Being Dedicated to Truth

Being proven wrong is unpleasant for people with this personality type, even more so when they're stubborn about being wrong. Yet that may be the result when Debaters impatiently take shortcuts to learning or completing assignments. They can fall into the trap of believing that they're right no matter what, even if they haven't proven it yet. However, when Debaters circumvent prescribed learning processes, they weaken their grasp of information, leaving themselves vulnerable to ignorance that others may reveal.

That fact alone provides strong motivation for them to be both studious and conscientious. Feeling as though they're at the head of the class is

no excuse to shirk the work. When Debaters force themselves to focus, they build a solid foundation of knowledge that makes their opinions and arguments strong as well. A sharp wit can carry Debaters only so far in life; dedication and time are the only ways they can gain true knowledge. Luckily, they absorb facts like sponges when they maintain dedicated attention. The following exercise can help them hone their focus and attack their studies in an effective, efficient way:

- Create a study schedule with specific goals and a realistic, detailed timeline to achieve those goals.
    - For example, becoming fluent in French in 30 days isn't realistic, but becoming proficient in French in six months may be achievable.
    - The timeline should include specific time(s) set aside every day for study, as well as markers to check progress, such as passing level one French tests online after three months of study.
- Use multiple forms of accountability, such as reminders on a cell phone as well as a friend or family member who checks in to make sure goals are being achieved.
- Build flexibility into your plan to avoid burnout. Take breaks for self-care, and don't neglect other areas of life, such as relationships, hobbies, and work.

Schedules may seem restrictive, but Debaters who learn to utilize them effectively – and with plenty of built-in flexibility – find it easier and more enjoyable to meet their educational goals.

Debaters in High School

Following their endless enthusiasm and wide-ranging interests, Debater students pursue opportunities to increase their learning, albeit on their own terms. This is especially true if they view their years in high school as a valuable learning experience – or, at the very least, as an obstacle to overcome as quickly as possible. If they value what they're learning, they're more than capable of being competent students. However, those motivated by a desire to escape an uninspiring curriculum or unengaged instructors will undoubtedly approach high school with greater animosity than those whose teachers and coursework respect Debaters' insight.

Even Debaters who are adept in their studies may find the high school experience to be challenging. Tedious homework assignments and interminable lectures wear on them over time, and they may allow their boredom to overwhelm their desire to maintain a decent grade point average. When it comes to the social aspects of high school, Debaters may struggle to connect with peers and teachers in and outside the classroom if they challenge the status quo too much. Playing devil's advocate is certainly useful at times, but incessantly challenging others' perspectives can garner more ill will than respect.

Balanced High School Learning

Exploring Ideas

Many Debaters, with their desire to explore and expand upon the world around them, find themselves drawn toward classes, projects, and extracurricular activities that encourage free thinking and innovation. Creative writing assignments, robotics competitions, and student council meetings all provide opportunities for the challenge and exploration they crave. When they focus their energy on a topic of interest, Debater students are capable of genuinely excelling.

If they utilize their traits in truly open-minded ways, Debaters can do well even in classes and activities that don't directly correspond to their interests. For instance, they may not be particularly excited about chemistry, but deeper understanding of the periodic table can be just as valuable as any other skill. Simply the ability to learn new information, fascinating or not, is itself a desirable and necessary skill to develop. Debaters who can overcome their disinterest in certain subjects or topics tend to excel in the classroom and master the skills necessary for future success.

Plotting Their Own Course

Like many high school students, Debaters may find themselves drawn to the competitive spirit of sports or the artistic challenge of music and theater – although they may find that their intellectual approach lacks the immediacy that so many seek in athletics and the arts alike. Other Debater students may find it more intellectually fulfilling to participate

in gaming clubs or other specialized interest groups more in line with their nature.

Spurred on by their curiosity and sharp wit, Debater students may consider many sports, clubs, and other extracurricular activities until they find the ones that resonate with them the most. They understand that finding an activity that enthuses them takes time. And when things don't work out, resilient Debaters simply tuck away the knowledge they've gained and try something else. This mentality serves them well later in life, as they delve into the exploratory process of determining a college major and/or potential careers.

Unbalanced High School Learning

The Class Showoff

Debaters seek attention. Although not inherently a bad thing, this tendency can easily distract them from their studies during their teenage years. When these students are more focused on gaining their peers' approval than focusing on schoolwork, teachers and administrators may have difficulty tolerating their rambunctious behavior. If Debaters lack consideration for others, they may ignore the genuine concerns of such authority figures.

This can carry over to their fellow students as well. As dominantly cerebral types, Debaters can lack warmth and deeper connections with their peers. They sometimes use their wit and mental agility to impress people – or put them down. Jokes, sarcastic comments, and witty retorts about people in charge are go-to maneuvers for teen Debaters. They may dismiss subjects and people that strike them as boring, and they often wear their contempt openly. Although these students are generally more than capable of academic success, the trap of being "too cool for school" can hinder their academic development.

Anything but Homework

Popularity often comes with distraction – and it borders on addictive for Debaters if they can't extricate their identity from their social standing. When the center of attention is their favorite place to be, Debaters may find themselves neglecting their studies to socialize.

Though they aren't necessarily adrenaline junkies, Debaters are often high-energy individuals. When their natural energy is combined with teenage hormones and an active social life, they may find themselves seeking out adventure rather than focusing on their education. When school is unable to engage their attention or stoke their passion, Debaters tend to confidently shirk their studies to pursue interests outside of school.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Putting in the Effort

To combat a lack of sincere attention to academics, Debaters who feel they're above the work can prove it by excelling. Nothing demonstrates their superiority better than a concrete example – after that, there's nothing wrong with poking fun at the system. Debaters who use their minds fully and more efficiently earn the right to stand up and declare their ability, and if it wins the admiration of others, that too is deserved.

These students should keep in mind that drawing attention to themselves sometimes means pulling focus from the education process for other people. There's room for showing off their knowledge and even making a few well-placed jokes, *if* they respect the fact that a classroom is first and foremost a place of learning. One way they can get their work done and let others get their work done as well is to intentionally set goals for themselves. Setting aside specific times for work and play can help Debater students stay focused on accomplishing their goals while ensuring plenty of time to cut loose. Specifically, they can try the following:

- Address the tendency to be distracted by setting small, achievable schoolwork goals.
- Once the goals are accomplished, take some time to goof off a little.
- Confine the latter to breaks or between classes to avoid friction with others.

Debaters are much more likely to be taken seriously as knowledgeable individuals when they prove their ability to focus on and accomplish

important tasks. Rather than relying on wit and well-timed humor, they can work toward being legitimately well-prepared – something that can earn them more respect with teachers, classmates, and future employers alike.

Find Something to Get Excited About

With their inconsistent attention span, argumentative nature, and sharply logical tendencies, Debaters often struggle to care about something that seems as arbitrary as homework. In high school especially, it can be difficult to balance their desire for intrigue with the necessity of meeting educational goals. One of the most effective ways these students can fuel their passion for peer interaction while also engaging with schoolwork is to join a group. While providing the social component that Debaters so thoroughly enjoy, groups often provide a measure of accountability as well: Many groups require students to maintain certain grade point averages to remain involved.

Debaters may join any group that represents their interests. Volunteerism is an excellent way to jump into dynamic learning environments. Any place from a machine shop to a zoo might be willing to take on an apprentice. A charity or even a political club that speaks to Debaters' views is the perfect place to learn and practice such skills as focus, perseverance, and positive communication. Learning activities look good on college applications, and, more importantly, they help Debaters practice skills that give them an edge in school and later in life. Participating in activities outside school gives them a chance to learn in a more versatile environment. Here are several criteria Debaters can follow to accomplish such balance:

- First: Find something that piques your interest enough that you want to engage and explore it further.
- Second: Choose a place that values participants.
- Third: Ensure the activity represents learning, not just entertainment. Social skills and cooperation likely will play a part, as they will significantly enhance Debaters' ability to learn.

As an example, Debaters who enjoy sports could create informal peer leagues – even if it's only two teams, they can come together and organize.

This is an excellent chance to practice the follow-through this personality type sometimes lacks. Alternatively, Debaters could run tabletop game campaigns, making a dedicated effort to ensure that everyone is respected, the rules are observed impartially, and fun abounds.

Mastering an equitable yet powerful balance between participation and observation can take Debaters far in their education and beyond. Additionally, being involved in groups that allow them to practice positive interactions but also gain skills and knowledge is invaluable. Such skills look good to colleges and potential employers but, most importantly, set Debaters up for healthier relationships as well as more effective social and technical skills.

Deciding Whether and When to Attend College

Many reasons factor into the decision whether to go to college, including personality type. Not long ago, most thought of college or university as the quickest path to success and security. Some of those same people now vigorously argue against higher education for everyone, having seen college graduates struggle in their careers and having seen college dropouts succeed on a grand scale in our technological age – Steve Jobs and Bill Gates being two famous examples.

Indeed, some individuals have been highly successful despite their lack of a college degree. However, even though a college degree may not be *necessary* for success, it makes one much more likely to find work that pays well. Many careers, even entry-level positions, require some sort of college degree or certification even to apply. In addition, studies show that individuals who have a diploma from an institution of higher education earn, on average, as much as $1 million more over a lifetime than those with only a high school diploma.

There's a niche for everyone, and college is just one possible path to finding it. So, what should Debaters consider when thinking about college?

"Will a degree be necessary for the work I want to pursue?"

Debaters who pursue college are often drawn to professional careers that demand the specialized expertise represented by a degree in

those fields. Enterprising Debaters might find occasional loopholes that allow them to pursue such careers without years spent in academia. However, those who desire a profession in science, engineering, law, or a variety of other fields may find that a degree is the most expedient – and sometimes the only – route to their destination, regardless of how much they might resent the delay.

Debaters who find college to be too restrictive or too slow-paced may find success by striking out on their own, which is admirable. However, even the most brilliant may have difficulty demonstrating their ingenuity without the necessary paperwork to back their claims.

"Will I gain something intangible, yet valuable, from going to college?"

For Debaters, higher education can have value beyond the certificate granted. Those interested in technological fields may have trouble finding the necessary resources to pursue such interests – computer equipment, lab apparatus, and database access – a problem that college may remedy.

University professors are also valuable resources for Debaters. Even if they're inclined to view their instructors as adversaries rather than mentors, the friction of classroom debate is a powerful means of strengthening untested ideas.

Finally, Debaters can use college as a means of deferring work to determine what they truly want in a career. By using scholarships, loans, or other financial safety nets, Debaters can use the relatively unfettered time and space that accompany higher education to realize their intellectual potential.

Debaters live for exciting challenges, and higher education offers an excellent environment where they can test their limits. Those who had a positive high school experience are likely to find that college provides even greater opportunities for their intellectual growth. Debaters who found high school to be too conventional and lacking in meaningful choices may be pleasantly surprised by their newfound ability to shape a curriculum to their liking.

Balanced Decision-Making

The Search for Knowledge

Students with a reasonable perspective understand that no matter how much they know, the amount left to learn is always far greater. A formal education not only helps satisfy their thirst for knowledge but also provides hands-on learning. When deciding whether and when to attend college, Debaters do well to allow their passion for learning to lead them wherever they can gain the most useful experience.

Debaters don't just want knowledge; they crave challenges and excitement. They know they need more than just logic to make their arguments, that it takes a well-grounded sense of reality and the ability to draw on vast stores of personal experience. People with this personality type don't only want to convince people they're right, they want to *be* right – and for that, there's no substitute for dedicated learning. Whether this means a traditional education, on-the-job learning, or lifelong learning, Debater students wisely place themselves where they can continuously learn, grow, and feed their intellect with solid facts.

Knowing When to Get an Education

Some Debaters who place themselves in a work environment too early run the risk of entering a cycle of rehashing what they already know. However, because they love obtaining knowledge, they can sense when they're stuck intellectually. Also, they tend to understand it's never too late to go back to school to gather more knowledge. People with this personality type have little trouble seeing when they're stagnating, and their Prospecting trait helps them to move in a different direction when necessary.

This is just as true for Debaters who engage in traditional education and find it limiting. Although it can be risky in the long term to abandon early efforts toward a degree, sometimes alternate opportunities appear. If a job opportunity comes along, or a chance for unconventional education, Debaters understand that they're allowed to put college on hold to try something else. Their independent viewpoint provides them with the flexibility to see and embrace such opportunities.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Decision Paralysis

It may seem beneficial to survey a multitude of opportunities for formal and informal education on top of vast career options. However, Debaters who struggle with setting realistic, achievable goals may find themselves unable to form thoughtful academic and career plans. What may start off as initially exciting ventures can quickly be tossed aside for newer, seemingly better ideas once the first ones get too difficult.

Frequently switching majors, for example, not only puts students behind in terms of courses they need to take, it also often leads to more tuition bills. Potential employers (and even romantic partners) tend to pass on people who are unable to finish what they start. Though the world may be their oyster, Debaters still need to determine which sea to fish in, or they may spend their lives floating aimlessly through choppy waters.

Opinions Take Precedence

Debaters can easily lean on opinions rather than knowledge. It takes little learning for people with this personality type to *seem* wise because their agile minds often make the best use of information and facts. This can cause some to have a drastically inflated sense of their own knowledge, which can make college seem useless. Yet such overconfidence can be a mistake that poisons a lifetime of potential achievement.

Bypassing college isn't automatically harmful, but Debaters should beware of doing so out of a false sense of intellectual accomplishment. Whether enrolling in school or choosing immediate entry into the workforce, those who decide they already know enough may cement their lack of knowledge. They may give themselves a false sense that they aren't stagnating by drilling down on what they already know and exploring the same intellectual ground – creating a veritable echo chamber for their current knowledge and opinions.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Knowing When to Stay

Other personality types might struggle with deciding to jump and change

their approach if they find that work or college isn't what they expected. Debaters may experience the opposite issue, reassessing their choices so early and so often that they make themselves miserable. Beneath their opinionated exteriors, Debaters with imbalanced self-esteem or self-respect may second-guess themselves, with painful results. This internal unease can lead them to give up on the path they chose – whether a career or college – before they've given it a fair chance.

Developing a philosophy that values the importance of focus and perseverance can be especially valuable for anxious Debaters. Instead of deciding a path is "wrong" as soon as it doesn't "feel good" – or when another path looks more appealing – perhaps a better approach is to look at the experience as a worthy experiment, taking time to examine it rigorously before leaping to a conclusion. To do this, here are five groups of questions Debaters can ask themselves:

- What are the consequences of staying this course for another year? What are the opportunity costs? What is the best-case scenario?
- Is there potential for growth? Am I learning new skills, or am I gaining new knowledge and understanding? What opportunities will I have for growth and learning by staying this course for another year?
- Do I have a sense of connection or purpose on this path? If not, how can I find and cultivate a sense of purpose?
- Do I have a clear vision of where this current path will lead? If so, do I like it? If not, what does the lack of clarity mean, and how does it impact my decision-making?
- Am I pushing away or ignoring mentors, peers, or others who could provide encouragement or advice? If so, what concrete first step can I take today to connect with them?

By writing down answers to the above questions and ideally sharing the insights with trusted friends or advisors, Debaters can break out of the mental cycle that leads them to question their decisions reflexively rather than reflectively. It can help them gain the insight and strength required to take a positive next step – whether that means staying the course or moving on to something new.

Opening Perspectives

Debaters can't decide on the right path without an idea of what makes a path "right." Sometimes they struggle because they assume they already have the information they need. People with this personality type may need to free their minds to take in a greater breadth of information. One way is to humbly seek out those more advanced along their chosen academic or career path and ask them for insight and wisdom that come only from experience. Knowledge is powerful when it comes to decision-making, and the more knowledge Debaters have, the broader their perspectives can be.

Perhaps they might even "adopt" mentors; after all, nothing provides perspective like witnessing possibilities through the eyes of people who have already lived them. Such perspective might even inspire Debaters to project themselves onto a successful trajectory as they view potential paths through the lens of their mentors' self-confidence and experience. This can help with work, college, or graduate degree considerations. Here are some guidelines Debaters can use when finding mentors to help with the decision-making process:

- Decide before starting that making such an important decision is dynamic, and that concrete answers are likely to form only after an extended period of exploration. In other words, there are no easy answers – so good mentors don't typically provide them.
- Talk to – or read about – a variety of experienced people to help develop a specific direction.
- Check whether any organizations provide mentoring to students considering careers. It can be daunting for someone not yet in college or in a career to connect with mentors, but an ever-increasing dialogue between schools and businesses means that organizations on both sides often work together to help.
- Summer internships or work-study opportunities can be immensely helpful to Debaters trying to determine whether they need a college education.

Mentors provide the knowledge and accountability that Debaters crave, and they also serve as fantastic sources of otherwise difficult-to-find information – either through their own knowledge or through the vast

networks of other experts to whom they have access. When it comes to deciding something as important as whether to attend college, resources like mentors who can provide information and support are absolutely invaluable.

Debaters in College

For Debaters who choose to attend college, higher education offers an excellent environment in which to test their limits. People with this personality type live for a good challenge, and college can certainly offer gratifying opportunities for growth and development.

Balanced Approach to College

Endless Opportunities

In college, Debaters' wide-ranging curiosity serves them well. Thumbing through a course catalog can be a fascinating exercise for them as they discover plenty of course offerings and extracurricular activities to capture their interest. College environments that encourage interdisciplinary or entrepreneurial studies can be especially gratifying for people with this personality type. By bridging different disciplines, such studies offer Debater students an opportunity to think outside the box and make unexpected connections – two of their favorite intellectual maneuvers.

If they carry this sense of engagement to required courses and prerequisites, Debaters stand to gain even more from the college experience. Although they'll likely prefer the courses they elect over predetermined requirements, those who take an open-minded approach allow their imaginations to be sparked by *all* their classes, even those that lie outside their interests. Looking at every course or activity as a learning opportunity can set Debater students up for more positive learning (and social) college experiences.

Kindred Spirits

With the plethora of fresh faces and new resources available at most college campuses, Debaters are likely to be thrilled with the social and educational opportunities available to them. This is especially true if

they find people who share their less-common interests. Debater students are also likely to delight in encountering people who *don't* share their interests, as they can open Debaters' eyes to new thoughts and fascinations and provide opportunities for entertaining debates and conversations. New connections can evolve into friendships and collaborations that offer Debaters the inspiration and exposure to fresh ideas they so crave.

In addition to providing companionship, new relationships can expose Debaters to new academic ideas, knowledge, and beliefs. Truly open-minded Debaters are excited to find new information, regardless of whether it supports their previously held beliefs and opinions. With their unique backgrounds and personal stories, new acquaintances are a wealth of new knowledge. From lively debates to study groups to game nights, Debaters can find ways to engage peers and professors alike in intellectual discourse that feeds their curiosity and desire for human interaction.

Unbalanced Approach to College

Narrowing Horizons

If they decide to pursue college, Debaters with outsized egos can inadvertently limit their academic horizons. They may allow their strong views to limit their choice of courses, leading them to focus on what they've decided is "worthwhile" while ignoring what could unexpectedly become so. They might also blow off required courses that don't align with their personal interests.

To put it bluntly, Debater students who regard required courses with resentment – or write off entire fields of study – waste potentially important learning experiences. Required courses, when approached in the right spirit, can lay the groundwork for skills that can serve Debaters throughout their lives. Such skills might lead to future professional opportunities, or they might simply be interesting to learn. Unless they force themselves into unknown terrain – which entails opening their minds to fields of study that don't immediately seem "useful" or "rational" – Debaters stay stuck in their comfort zones, severely limiting their personal growth.

Questioning Everything, Respecting Nothing

When facing new ideas in college, Debaters who get stuck on past conceptions often exhibit a confrontational, argumentative style that interferes with learning. Fixating on minor fallacies, which abound everywhere and rarely matter in any material way, can cause Debaters students to miss the bigger picture. They may be so caught up in competitive intellectual sparring over principles and semantics that they miss bigger truths with less-defined edges. Debaters whose confidence depends on how others perceive their intelligence may endlessly argue over details, but teachers and peers may simply move on without them.

Ego is often the source of such imbalance. When Debaters feel a need to prove themselves right, they can go to great lengths to attack or impress others. Given the nature of logic, it can easily be misused as a weapon; when Debaters do so, they often win. However, what they win is merely an inflated sense of self, as beating people in arguments does little to advance their own minds or bring in new knowledge. Teachers and fellow students alike quickly tire of Debaters who focus more on speaking their minds – or dominating others – instead of fairly considering contrasting opinions or new information.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Learning from Everything

For Debaters, there are concrete benefits to finding the value inherent even in subjects that seem dull or pointless – including seemingly arbitrary prerequisites and required courses. Given their increased maturity, people with this personality type are more likely to seek opportunities for personal development and growth in such courses and assignments. The attention to detail and memorization that strictly defined courses require might help Debaters become better at tolerating and dealing with the mundane – a key component of achieving the goals they set for themselves.

With this mindset, many worthwhile things can happen. First, Debaters may gain the discipline that provides much-needed balance to their intellectual enthusiasm. They can learn the value of being stricter with

themselves when it comes to life's more insistent details. Moreover, they can view the hours spent in such classes as valuable rather than a useless and artificial waste of time. Eventually, their perception of a class may change from tragically hollow to authentically worthwhile.

To enhance the process, Debaters can try the following exercise:

- Identify a subject that doesn't feel particularly interesting or worthwhile, especially if it's a required course.
- Meet with someone who is majoring in that subject or pursuing a related career. Ask questions: Why would someone become a pathologist, or a geographer, or a marine biologist? What's special or meaningful about the subject? What challenges does the field address, and how can it benefit humankind?
- Befriend someone who has academic interests that are seemingly dull or unnecessary. Take the time to really consider what value that area of focus has, both for that individual and for others who may benefit from it. For example, accounting isn't just crunching numbers on spreadsheets – it helps to organize financial resources for intrepid Debater entrepreneurs.

Overcoming a tendency to be "right" rather than considerate is a challenge Debaters may face in academics and life. By taking a path of investigation and inquiry, however, Debaters might just discover new passions and develop new friendships they wouldn't have otherwise.

Respecting Other Views

When learning, Debaters may disregard the opinions of people they consider less intelligent, including instructors and fellow students. However, true learning requires gaining perspectives different from those they already hold. Rejecting other perspectives only results in ignorance. Even when others' perspectives are provably false, knowledge and truth can be found in fiction as readily as any documentary. Seekers often find treasures in the least expected places. Openness to others is the key to broadening understanding.

When Debaters open themselves to others' perspectives, they also open themselves up to a greater wealth of possibilities. If they humble

themselves appropriately, they can gain well-rounded evidence and insight that make their opinions and arguments stronger. A willingness to prove verifiable ideas is an excellent way to continually learn. Debaters can try the following experiment to apply scrutiny to ideas and beliefs:

- Pick a topic that interests you. The stronger your opinion about the topic (good or bad), the better.
- Find a club, organization, or even religious service to attend, primarily as an observer.
- When attending the meeting or service, look for any comments or discussions that contain information contrary to your personal beliefs. (It's important, however, to resist debating anyone. This exercise is purely for gathering information and observing to challenge your own beliefs – not to criticize or persuade someone else.)
- Rarely are people totally wrong, so there's likely at least one point you can appreciate, regardless of whether you agree with the overall position. Keep in mind that you needn't embrace the point or position; simply acknowledge that the perspective has some merit.
- Consider other ideas you have that might deserve the same scrutiny. The more people test an idea, the more accurate the idea is likely to be – this holds as well for day-to-day disagreement as it does for peer review in the scientific method.

By recognizing that many viewpoints can have valid components, Debaters can learn to respect peers and instructors whose approach to learning and overall understanding of the world around them are different from their own. After all, only by questioning any knee-jerk dismissals of other opinions can Debaters truly earn the right to consider themselves open-minded.

Lifelong Learning

For many, "learning" and "formal education" are virtually synonymous. Both terms are bound by the institutions that govern them: the schools and universities that confer certificates upon graduation. Debaters, who are often ambivalent about the prospect of formal education, are less likely to make this association as easily. They simultaneously revere

the academic world for its potential to further their own interests yet remain acutely aware of its uses as a tool for indoctrination. People with this personality type feel the need to take the world by storm and turn to education only when necessary, gathering from it what they need while trying to rush through the irrelevant as quickly as possible.

To outside observers, Debaters may have strange notions of what counts as "necessary," as they rely on their own definition rather than that of society. However, Debaters who refuse to admit that there may be different but equally acceptable options tend to continue treading the same well-worn paths. They'll stubbornly insist that, although they haven't learned everything there is to know, they know what they consider important.

Debaters continue to learn if their need to innovate continues. If they want to build solar panels, then they'll strive to be amateur engineers. If they want to market and own companies that sell solar panels, then they'll take the steps needed to become business magnates. They never stop innovating, so they never stop learning.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Enthusiastic Exploration

Self-aware Debaters understand that even though they have a strong desire to explore new things, they may need some time to find a way to learn outside the classroom that truly enthuses them. To move things along, they can leverage their sharp minds, trying out many things until they find the right one. Anything from an improv class to a debating society might tickle their fancy, but they won't know until they try it. When things don't work out, they can simply tuck away the knowledge gained and try something else.

Debaters are never at a loss for something that grabs their interest and drives them to learn more. When it comes to lifelong learning, they do well to not only thoughtfully follow their passions but also take a rational look at the benefits of varying paths – beyond just initial appeal. Of course, "Because I want to try it," is a perfectly good reason to sign up for a class or take on a new activity.

Practice, Focus, and Consistency

When well-adjusted Debaters find an area of learning they enjoy – whether composing sonatas or training for memory competitions – they stick with it. This can be a challenge, particularly when they reach a plateau in their progress. At that point, their initial enthusiasm might wane, and other activities might start to look awfully appealing. By forging through that stage, Debaters can cultivate focus; find the enjoyment inherent in applying themselves and testing their limits; and reap the rewards of diligent, consistent learning.

As they mature, Debaters come to understand how precious it is when they find a subject inspiring. As a result, they dig in with both hands and unrelenting curiosity, knowing that they can always go deeper in their learning. They avoid distractions – or incorporate them – and manage their attention, attending to only those things that they can incorporate into their learning.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Living in an Echo Chamber

Changes in society and technology mean that more than ever before, we can teach ourselves. Online videos and web content are a boon for would-be autodidacts. That said, some things are learned much more easily from other people. This can be hard for Debaters to swallow, particularly if they assume they "know best" and can figure out everything on their own. Even Debaters who recognize the value of others' wisdom and experience may still only prescribe to the teaching of a very select few, deeming only those they agree with as worthy of their time.

Debaters' independence can be commendable, but if they focus on acquiring only information that already supports their point of view, they will find themselves living in an unenlightened echo chamber. There are benefits to becoming deeply knowledgeable about a specific topic, but refusing to consider opposing information is dangerous due to the unnecessary conflict it inevitably creates, as well as the narrow-mindedness that follows.

Giving Up Too Soon

When asked what they'd most like to learn, Debaters aren't hard pressed to come up with at least a few answers. Their wide-ranging enthusiasm is among their greatest strengths, but if it isn't matched by consistency, healthy self-discipline, and the willingness to stick with difficult pursuits, it won't get them anywhere. Even worse: A series of "failed" experiences can erode their self-respect.

Most Debaters find it easier to start something than to finish it. There's nothing inherently wrong with that – in fact, it enables them to stand out as creative visionaries. But if they don't push past the internal resistance that arises whenever a project becomes difficult – and it's worth noting that resistance might come disguised as boredom or a sudden interest in a different endeavor – Debaters will flit from one area of learning to another, embracing a succession of short-lived hobbies. After a period of years or decades, they may look back and realize that they've scratched the surface of a great many subjects but never achieved true depth or mastery in any of them.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Breaking Out of the Box

Although they can learn much independently, Debaters may find that their course to lifelong learning runs more smoothly when they involve other points of view. They might consider drawing upon relevant teachers, seeking previously unconsidered learning environments, or simply attending talks and events that cover opposing views. Such avenues can offer Debaters opportunities to hear new ideas and consider new perspectives.

When they drop their biases, most Debaters see quite clearly that they can learn from and enjoy stimulating conversations with all manner of people with all manner of beliefs and ideas. Moreover, they can offer their own insights in return. This creates a model of learning that's informal, egalitarian, and dynamic – three qualities that suit Debaters well and allow them to enjoy the concrete as well as the ineffable benefits of an open-minded approach to learning.

To begin looking at learning from a more open-minded perspective, Debaters can try the following:

- Look for non-traditional learning opportunities, such as local meet-ups, talks, and events.
- When considering and evaluating instructors, keep an open mind. Take on the intellectual challenge of figuring out everything they *can* teach, rather than the easier track of focusing on their limitations.
- Prioritize learning experiences not previously considered. Honoring personal beliefs is important, but so is stretching comfort zones to add dimensions to life, and new perspectives often provide such stretches.
- Seek out opportunities to learn and grow during each of the experiences.
- When taking classes, look for interactive options. Lectures from podiums and somewhat passive audiences often limit the ability to hear others' opinions face-to-face. Activity-based classes provide great opportunities for communal learning, which is more inspiring for Debaters.

For Debaters, there's nothing wrong with taking an in-depth, independent approach to learning, if they feel they get what they need out of life. However, if they want to expand their lives and accelerate their learning, they may want to explore other ideas, information, and opinions that can bring more dimension to their knowledge and their lives in general.

Making Space for Learning

When a learning experience loses its initial gleam, Debaters may feel frustrated, uninspired, or vaguely disappointed. That's natural, but unless they reclaim their initial enthusiasm for the subject, they run the risk of giving up entirely. In such situations, many Debaters find themselves falling into the rut of trying to distract themselves or numb out by repeatedly absorbing themselves in other forms of entertainment – such as partying, playing video games, or even impulsively flitting from potential hobby to potential hobby without every fully engaging in any of them. Although such activities are gratifying in the moment, they can crowd out learning and other experiences that Debaters would find more enriching.

To be sure, there's nothing inherently wrong with indulging in other forms of entertainment. In fact, hanging out with friends and exploring (multiple) different hobbies can offer copious inspiration. But when Debaters fail to set boundaries around such activities, idle engagement can absorb time and energy they might otherwise spend on their passions. And when they've spent enough time away from an activity or project that once mattered to them, Debaters might find it surprisingly difficult to get back on the horse.

To make more time for learning in their lives, Debaters can experiment with an "entertainment ban":

- Identify a form of entertainment that takes up more time in daily life than you prefer.
- Choose a side project, learning experience, or hobby that's a high priority. Ensure that you have everything necessary to pursue the project, such as supplies, books, or other resources.
- Ban the form of entertainment identified in step one for a set period of time, anything from a weekend to a month – what matters is that it's an achievable amount of time and that you adhere to it.
- Use at least some of the time and attention otherwise devoted to that form of entertainment to pursue the interest from step two.
- Recruit a friend as an accountability partner who can check in regularly and encourage you to stay on track.

Debaters might be surprised by the power that distracting entertainment once held over them – and the amount of time and energy they can finally devote to their interests.

Conclusion

Academics are about more than just learning the traditional topics of reading, writing, and arithmetic. A truly well-rounded education encourages students to love the process of learning and seeking out information itself. Debaters are naturally curious and eager to learn, often pursuing education just for the sake of obtaining more knowledge – even if the only reason they want to learn is to prove themselves right. Their passion for acquiring information is admirable and can set

Debaters on the fast track to future success in their chosen occupation, as well as personal enrichment, if they're able to remain focused on the task at hand.

Fortunately, dedication and open-mindedness are skills that can be learned both inside and outside a formal classroom. Debaters who take time to balance their love of learning, their passion for communicating their ideas, some compassion, and at least a little bit of humility can find themselves not only learning more but also creating more meaningful relationships with those around them.

Some people spend nearly one-third of their lives studying. Some choose to enter the workforce earlier and don't spend as much time in classes or libraries. But most people spend at least some of their crucial formative years in school. No matter how long one remains in the academic world, the time is valuable and can establish the first steps on a path into the future. The school experience can affect lifelong self-esteem and other aspects of psychology. With the right attitude and the right choices, Debaters can make the best of that experience.

Professional Development

Debaters' primary professional challenge is finding a career that accommodates their unique style and their need to develop and defend their complex ideas. Then again, as a segment of the workforce, they surprise themselves and others by thriving in seemingly unsuitable careers. There's no one career (or even professional category) that all Debaters must squeeze into. Instead of looking for a non-existent, one-size-fits-all-Debaters job, people with this personality type may want to consider how different parts of any given position might play to their individual strengths. Perhaps more than anything else, Debaters are especially sensitive to the challenges a job provides. They prefer work that makes them think. A post or profession lacking an acceptable degree of intricacy, one that doesn't continually test their imagination, won't satisfy them for long.

As an uncommon personality type, Debaters bring their unique perspective and energy to anything they do. They also have personal skills that can help them adapt to work environments that don't line up neatly with their style and preferences. In the sections that follow, we'll discuss their traits and how they can use their skills to achieve balance and excel in professional development. We'll explore what may cause them excitement, frustration, and boredom in their jobs. We hope this guide gives Debaters the understanding and tools to help them as they consider engaging and rewarding career paths.

Thriving on Theories and Ideas

One of the most prominent personality traits shared by all Debaters is their love for analytical methods and ideas. The best careers turn this

trait into a significant strength, as few other personality types enjoy abstract concepts as much as they do. Many become distinguished career scientists, mathematicians, and system analysts, but they're far from limited to these fields. Debaters bring their reasoning skills to many workplaces – they'd be hard-pressed to find a job that has no opportunities for problem-solving at all.

Debaters typically enjoy finding and analyzing underlying principles and ideas, and they delight in sharing such information with others. Many career paths fulfill them in this way, and jobs that come with compelling challenges make Debaters even happier. They're fascinated by research, pattern-seeking, hypotheses, possibilities, and alternatives, making them great corporate strategists, business analysts, video game designers, programmers, and engineers. Regardless of the area, Debaters are system designers at heart. Although this might immediately bring inanimate systems to mind, Debaters can also envision human systems made up of skilled people interconnecting for greater effectiveness. Debaters perceive their environment as something that can be shaped and fashioned according to their ideas.

People with this personality type are highly analytical, focused, and intelligent, and they surpass many other personality types regarding organizational skills and precise thinking. This makes them masters at theoretical foundations and structures, but such impersonal solutions can prevent them from applying enough empathy to win over others. They can, at times, be more interested in winning minds rather than hearts, creating a chasm between themselves and the people whose support they may need.

In other words, Debaters tend to do best when they fill a niche that honors their rational ways. This doesn't mean that they can't expand and branch out in more practical directions, or that they lack the social skills to win people over – quite the contrary, at times. Their "true North" is the theoretical, though, which significantly influences how they work.

Ever-Expanding Knowledge Base

Debaters usually excel at both brainstorming and inventing, due to their capacity to rapidly absorb new knowledge, especially technical information. They have a significant advantage over other personality

types for remembering and accessing knowledge. Debaters are so interested in absorbing new information that they seek vast amounts of knowledge on multiple subjects. Their careers are only one aspect of their lives, and most have interests, hobbies, and ideas they follow with enthusiasm outside working hours. Even if the information they gain from such interests doesn't offer immediate benefits, they realize that it may prove useful at some point.

However, this mostly healthy focus has a couple of downsides. Debaters are only satisfied with their career paths when they're confident they'll find enough intellectual stimulation along the way. Professions that aren't challenging or interesting make them restless and frustrated, which can prompt them to satisfy their curiosity in ways that don't always align with their job requirements or their organization's goals.

Unlike some other personality types, Debaters rarely actually satisfy their curiosity. They're always looking for new processes and refuse to accept unsatisfying or incomplete answers. This makes them naturally great at pulling information together to brainstorm. Although excelling at brainstorming is a fantastic quality, continuing to brainstorm during subsequent project phases significantly slows down the process and can cause tension with coworkers, managers, or customers who need projects or products finished on reasonable timelines.

Incessantly tweaking an idea can produce a constant state of flux and disruption, turning solid goals into continually moving targets. This tendency can also lower morale, especially with more sensitive Feeling types. Other people may perceive that Debaters are questioning and contradicting their every move when, from the Debaters' perspective, they're usefully adding new information or challenging obsolete ideas. Debaters are at a clear disadvantage in such situations because they aren't always good at gauging others' emotions.

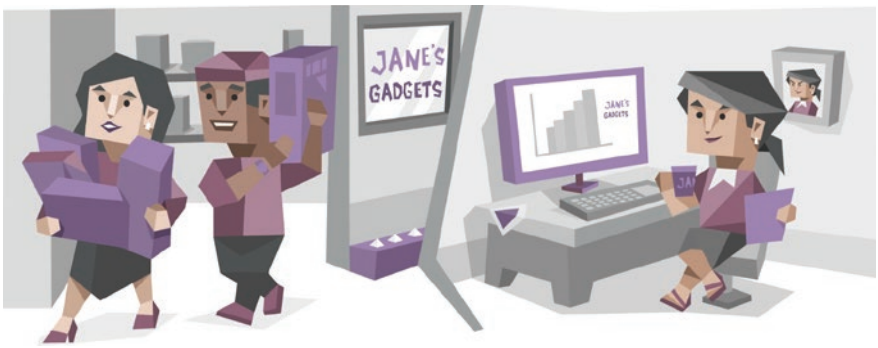
People with this personality type sometimes underappreciate their coworkers' roles (not to mention their pride and egos), placing rationality above all. The resultant misunderstandings and miscommunications can lead Debaters to misinterpret others' responses as resistance to growth. Rather than pulling back and giving their coworkers some much-needed space to understand and process information, Debaters may push even harder.

Work as an EQ Workshop

Debaters have much to offer in the workplace, but they have an opportunity to learn as well. They certainly can benefit from improving their emotional intelligence (otherwise known as EQ), and they may want to look at each contact as an opportunity to do so. Assisting a disgruntled customer, coworker, boss, or vendor can be an unpleasant experience. But such stressful events are some of the best opportunities for Debaters to practice skills such as empathy, non-judgment, and positive thinking. They may tend to tell stories and argue their positions excitingly with friends and colleagues, but working on their empathy often requires a deliberate change in behavior. Even if they find it difficult to engage empathetically in the heat of a frustrating encounter, taking the time to reflect (perhaps from the distance of the break room or later at home) can help them identify their triggers.

Social acuity is just as important as other skills, if not more so. Most consider it an essential element of professional development, but Debaters sometimes dismiss the idea because they see little value in small talk and socializing. They do, however, value personal growth, and they can benefit immensely by learning more about what drives and motivates other people. In the real world, sometimes defusing a situation with a problematic stakeholder offers more value than building a system that's twice as efficient as the old one. Such skills provide a tremendous advantage – at work and elsewhere.

Jobs and Skill Sets



As we discuss some specific jobs that suit Debaters' personality traits, keep in mind that the lists are by no means comprehensive. People with this personality type can succeed in any career they choose, and they're limited only by their interests and will. Even "suitable" jobs

mentioned here may not be ideal for all Debaters. The factors for deciding one's livelihood are broad and many. Everyone must determine what career is the most appropriate for them – what meets their needs and brings them fulfillment and personal satisfaction. Nonetheless, some jobs align with typical personality preferences, and we'll offer them here for those considering their futures.

Each category below represents a field that can benefit from Debaters' particular strengths, including some specific jobs that capitalize on their personal assets. For Debaters who are already employed, this section may serve as confirmation or an explanation for why they're happy or unhappy in their current role. But it can't be said enough: This section is descriptive and intended to foster insights and ideas; it isn't prescriptive in any way. Career choices must be based on a constellation of unique and varied personal elements. We can't tell anyone how to be successful or content, but we do hope the following material offers Debaters some insight when making career decisions.

Engineering and Design

Engineering and design are broad categories of disciplines that use science, math, design techniques, and ingenuity to create machines, structures, or systems. They not only create new products but also remove flaws from older products.

Debaters identify with this kind of work. They're "idea" people and pass their ideas on to others for implementation. But in the theoretical realm, there's nothing more satisfying for them than dreaming up ways to influence their environment or manipulate a system. Some jobs that might appeal them include the following.

- Software engineer
- Engineer of any type
- Architect
- Inventor
- Urban planner
- Environmental planner
- Video game designer

Research and Science

Debaters are passionate in their need to discover and explain how things work. Not only do they love the discovery, but they're also fond of the patterns that often reveal themselves in research, and they relish sharing their findings with others. They're likely to take the initiative to explore what no one has studied before or to find a different approach to older research.

Researchers and scientists with this personality type admire others with similar drive and abilities and collaborate if they feel they're dealing with equals. Debaters hope their discoveries can be used for practical applications and may become involved in such implementation. Their research extends beyond finding the answer, as they embrace how it may affect the future. Some of the jobs in this category include the following.

- Academic researcher or professor
- Physical scientist
- Life scientist
- Astronomer
- Medical researcher
- Physicist
- Psychological researcher

Medicine

In the medical field, Debaters often excel as diagnosticians and practitioners. Their Intuitive and Thinking traits allow these physicians to quickly assess symptom patterns and use them to make accurate diagnoses. They approach treatment the same way. They're inclined to try innovative measures when possible, should traditional therapies fail. Any of the following fields are full of potential medical puzzles to solve and would be satisfying to Debaters who are inclined to enter medicine.

- Psychiatrist
- Pathologist
- Neurologist

- Pharmacologist
- Cardiologist
- Diagnostician

Strategy

It's no accident that we categorize Debaters as "Analysts." Naming this section "Strategy" is cheating a little bit: Everything Debaters do is strategic in some fashion, but not all tactical jobs neatly fit into categories. So this section serves as a catch-all.

What do these jobs have in common? They all involve problems that need solutions, and they all require broad-scope thinking to expand understanding. With their entrepreneurial spirit, Debaters can come up with efficient and innovative solutions. Some jobs where such skills may come in handy include the following.

- Business or corporate strategist
- Management consultant
- Project manager
- Military officer
- Educational consultant
- Investment analyst
- Lawyer
- Security and intelligence position

Taking Up a Trade

Not all Debaters go to college, nor do they all want jobs that require advanced degrees and training. There are plenty of places outside of science and technology where their skills and preferences can serve them well.

Debaters are charismatic problem-solvers who love to discuss their ideas with others – a combination that naturally lends itself to sales jobs. They can also apply their strategic style of thinking to almost

anything, from efficient firefighting to making better burgers faster. The possibilities are too vast to list here and are limited only by their wants, needs, and imaginations.

Career Alternatives

Sometimes Debaters can't advance in the workplace; perhaps their employers don't value their unique traits, or maybe there just isn't room for growth. Aside from changing employers, Debaters who find themselves dissatisfied do have alternative options.

People don't need to work in the traditional sense to live comfortably. In this age of possibilities, selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to generate income. These days, even traditional employees don't have true job security or any guarantee of advancement. Working for oneself can be a viable option, and it offers many benefits that align with Debater values, including flexibility, independence, and control over projects. Thanks to their ability to create new ideas and make unexpected connections, these creative, bold individuals can thrive in self-employment and as entrepreneurs.

Self-Employment

Self-employment eliminates a significant hurdle Debaters may find in corporate environments: forced interaction with people with whom they disagree. Self-employed workers are somewhat freer to choose which tasks they want to perform and which they want to delegate or outsource. This means that independent Debaters can sidestep some of their pet peeves, including following orders and dealing with people who are unable (or unwilling) to improve. Self-employment offers many

significant benefits, especially in today's global and always-connected environment, and individuals with this personality type can find a great deal of success in such ventures.

Entrepreneurship

There's no point in trying to start a business without a good idea. That's where Debaters' ability to come up with unusual connections – intellectually and socially – enables them to shine. Anyone can think up a product, but Debaters have an edge in looking at a situation, discovering apparent needs or desires, finding a systemic solution that satisfies them, and then pulling together the people needed to make it happen. Consequently, a product or service is born.

It takes an imaginative mind with an independent bent – like that possessed by Debaters – to come up with an idea, product, or solution that has the potential to grow into an innovative business venture. There's a reason Google and Facebook were developed by geeks in their basements and dorm rooms rather than engineers working 9 to 5 at multinational companies. Debaters' style of thinking can spin off in unique ways to capture yet-undeveloped niches in business. When they get help with executing their visions from more hands-on individuals, they have even greater chances of success as entrepreneurs.

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, we spend a great deal of time at work, and we expect our careers to give us meaning. Debaters must be careful not to get stuck in jobs that don't suit their traits and temperaments, or they risk dissatisfaction and frustration. Following are characteristics of employment that may not be suitable for Debaters – but again, no occupation nor type of career is off the table. The information in this section is based on their common tendencies; it isn't meant to be absolute or restrictive.

Restrictive Environments

Debaters like to experiment and explore new ideas. Boundaries, structure, and rules that are too rigid can keep them from their comprehensive

exploration of possibilities. They're passionate puzzle-solvers and aren't happy when restrictions prevent them from exercising that passion. Debaters may not be able to function at their highest capacity in such environments, and they tend to lash out rather than conform to what they see as artificial and unnecessary hindrances to their intellectual process.

Too many standards and too much oversight make Debaters' focus too narrow for the way they gain insight. They need a free-range work environment that allows their rich imaginations to play. To function at their fullest, they need independence, not supervision. This doesn't mean they prefer to work alone, but they do need flexibility. Similarly, they may reject feeling locked into a career path that seems predetermined. They're happy just doing the work they're passionate about. Office politics and bureaucratic matters annoy them. Consequently, they may spend too much time railing against confining systems – time that could be spent contributing to an organization's goals instead.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Understanding how Debaters behave in various hierarchical roles is one thing; communicating their ideas to subordinates, colleagues, and managers effectively, across many personality types, is another entirely. Let's dig a little deeper to determine how Debaters can best cooperate with their coworkers.

Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Debaters and other Analysts who work together often find themselves "speaking the same language." They make rational arguments and engage in conceptual discussions. As colleagues, they may be very adept at perfecting specific and detailed concepts, but their minds are always

simultaneously scoping more extensive systems for opportunities to adjust and improve.

Balanced Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Systemic Brainstorming

With their penchant for solving puzzles, Debaters and other Analysts delve into systems and concepts, engaging in "what if" discussions about the things they explore with each other. They share a focus on improving any systems or enterprises they come across. They break them down into what works and what doesn't, try to find solutions for the problems, and rebuild (at least in theory) new models that support their analyses. In the workplace, Debater and Analyst coworkers have similar-enough styles of thinking that they can either confirm, correct, or expand each other's ideas with a sense of mutual credibility. Their shared methods increase the trust and comfort they have with each other's opinions, helping to create supportive work relationships.

Because they share a certain style, Debaters and other Analysts can be a perfect match for brainstorming or bouncing ideas off each other. Brainstorming between the two extends far beyond the meeting room. Both are likely to take the time to ponder the different facets of an idea, then continue discussions. "I was thinking about what you said..." may be a familiar refrain between these colleagues. Such a dynamic may create a partnership or even be the start of a team – whether deliberately or, more likely, as an unintended result of similar energies and styles meeting in the workplace.

Socially Compatible

Because people spend so much of their lives working, relationships with colleagues often involve more than just the job. Debater and Analyst coworkers often have a social kinship: Small talk interests neither, so they may find each other's company a relief from the tedium of the usual watercooler chat. What Debaters and Analysts consider conversation may be more complicated than most people are accustomed to in their casual tête-à-têtes. When an organization employs multiple Debaters and Analysts, these employees may find they finally have other people who can handle their sometimes-brash conversational styles.

Similarly, Debaters and other Analysts have contempt for ideological arguments, emotional appeals, and "soft" rationalizations. When they work together, they quickly spot those tendencies. If Debaters and other Analysts notice flaws or inconsistencies in a company or its leadership, they may form an "alliance of the like-minded" over the perceived weaknesses. Bonding over negative issues has potential dangers, but, if handled correctly, it can also provide fertile ground for positive change.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Constant Competition

One pitfall Debater and Analyst coworkers may face is the potential for constant competitive tension. Because they're somewhat rare, Debaters may not have had experience with other Analysts in the room. New encounters can be uncomfortable – especially when Debaters come across other Analysts who share their specific specialties. In career settings with a high concentration of Analysts, the competition can be extreme. Although these personality types aren't prone to drama in an emotional sense, their one-upmanship can cause extensive damage if it spills too much into the workday.

If Debaters and other Analysts become competitive with each other, they risk becoming entrenched in opposing ideas or unrelenting criticism of each other. Analysts are prone to freely show scorn for others' mistakes or displays of flawed logic, and terse remarks can ratchet up the heat as their egos become strongholds they must defend. Of all the Analysts, Debaters are the most likely to appreciate an argument, and they may even set them off intentionally for the fun of it. Where Debaters may envision a resulting synergy of ideas, the results can just as easily be a destructive rivalry where participants tear each other down to prove their intellectual superiority.

A Quagmire of Cleverness

Debaters and other Analysts who nurture their collaborative spirits can find themselves in a quagmire of genius. They may produce *too many* great ideas while brainstorming together. With each new diversion

requiring resources and entailing costs, these coworkers can become trapped in their cleverness, unable to move any one objective forward with the competence they so value. At some point, they may need to pull in less theoretical and more hands-on people to lend practical perspective.

Personality theories often refer to Intuitive types, such as Debaters and other Analysts, as "open-minded." However, they're open-minded largely in that they can see many options, which sometimes gives them the appearance of flexibility. Yet Debaters and other Analysts can be as stubborn or rigid as anybody else with ideas and obsessions – perhaps more. Such stubbornness can be especially problematic among Debater and Analyst coworkers if they believe their pet arguments are unassailable. Even when they're right about an idea, it doesn't necessarily fit all situations; as the adage goes, "When one only has a hammer, everything looks like a nail." Rather than pushing ideas that aren't relevant to a work situation or accepted by the powers that be, Debater-Analyst teams may need to compromise their position.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Healthy Competition

Not all competition between Debaters and other Analysts is damaging. Any negative impact depends on the level of hostility; it's more about the tone of the rivalry, such as malicious feelings or attitudes that might enter the contest. Sometimes competition is healthy. Good ideas and outcomes can arise when coworkers try to outdo each other, if they can keep their actions goal-oriented. If such rivalry persists for a lengthy period or is defined by winning more than results, it can distract from the original purpose. Therefore, tone, attitude, and level of efficiency all determine the value of competition.

Self-awareness is one of the first steps for Debaters who wish to transform toxic work competition with other Analysts into a healthier approach. Awareness of their namesake tendency can help Debaters moderate their voices and use their openness to opportunistic perspectives for good. They can choose a contrary attitude to confirm their sense of being right, or they can choose to offer opposing

viewpoints constructively, to add useful information or a significant new dimension to a plan. Self-awareness can provide choice, as well as freedom from impulsive arguments.

Setting up a system that fosters such insight can be a powerful tool for keeping toxic competition in check. The following method recognizes that the need to be right isn't in and of itself a terrible thing – if used in moderation, it can motivate Debaters in healthy ways. However, the more exclusively they focus on being right, the less likely they are to contribute in wholesome and effective ways. The exercise below isn't designed to pass judgment, but rather to increase mindful awareness of attitudes and their effects:

- Draw a horizontal line across an index card. On one end of the line, write, "Being right." On the other, write, "Contributing."
- Using an app or some other type of reminder tool, set a *random* alarm. Each time it goes off, take out the index card and ask yourself, "At this moment, where do my thoughts and focus fall on this continuum?" Do it for a week to make it a habit.
- Keep the card and use it as needed. Whenever an interaction feels tense and adversarial, take it out and think about your motivation and how it may be fueling a sense of competition.

If the personal need to triumph hinders measurable goals or even decelerates their progress, it can be objectively damaging. However, reasonable competition can be useful. If Debaters discover that "being right" motivates them too often, they may want to adjust their approach to ensure their value in the workplace.

Opening the Echo Chamber

Debaters and other Analysts sharing rational sensibilities at work can offer each other stimulation without having to wander too far from their comfort zones. With each reinforcing the other, they can create a sense of confidence or legitimacy around their ideas that isn't always deserved. Just because an opinion is well-reasoned, it doesn't necessarily make it useful, and Debater and Analyst coworkers can become stuck supporting notions that are worthless outside their bubbles. People often ignore theories that don't have clear and measurable results.

This is especially true in for-profit settings. Although such thoughts can be fun for Debaters and other Analysts to toss back and forth, if they become the primary focus or are mistaken for being useful, they can be detrimental.

In certain situations, Debater and Analyst coworkers may need to recognize when they're stuck in a loop of their own mental indulgences – and then discover ways to break it. Here are some fundamental questions they can ask to expose useless intellectual exercises at work:

- What concrete and measurable results are likely to result from this line of thinking?
- How does this idea align with my organization's established vision or mission statement?
- How much resistance is the idea likely to receive? Rank it from one (received with joy and fanfare) to 10 (likely a deal-breaker when it comes to keeping this job). If the number is lower, the idea may be worth pursuing. Perhaps the number can even be improved if the idea is tweaked slightly.
- Has management or a peer reviewed the idea for its relevance? Are others onboard with the concept? Who has the authority to decide such things?

Sometimes the questions above may reveal that an idea can't or shouldn't move forward. Letting go can be the hardest thing, but the following suggestions can help:

- Recognize that shelving an idea doesn't say anything about its quality, nor does doing so measure your worth or the merit of the idea. Plans are most often adopted simply because they're in the right place at the right time.
- Give opposing or alternate views a fair hearing. Debaters can be defensive advocates for their ideas and may need to deliberately hold their tongues as they listen.
- Similarly, adopt a "Beginner's Mind." This Zen principle of approaching everything with a fresh set of eyes forces its practitioners to drop preconceptions – an obvious step for letting go when stuck in

an unproductive cycle. Ask yourself, "If I was approaching this situation for the first time, what might I notice about it?" However, you need not abandon your experiences. Beginner's Mind involves using your experiences in a new way based on new perceptions or revised circumstances.

American poet Jeffrey McDaniel wrote, "I realize there's something incredibly honest about trees in winter, how they're experts at letting things go." Debaters aren't always so good at releasing their pet notions. However, letting go is a useful skill that they can learn and develop, with many potential benefits. For example, it can save time spent in futile endeavors, as well as conserve personal energy and mental capacity. It also may help them when they find themselves trapped with Analyst coworkers in an echo chamber of ideas.

Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

Debaters and Diplomat coworkers share the Intuitive trait, which lends them a sense of connection regardless of any differences they may have. A kinship emerges from their collective ability to see beyond the obvious. Their differences are as likely to offer wholesome balance as they are to cause conflict – it depends on their willingness to work together and to appreciate one another's gifts and preferences.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

Some Common Methods

Debaters and Diplomats prefer discussing the "big picture" rather than small details. Small talk may bore even the most social among

them. Both absorb new knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of Intuitive understanding. They're imaginative and creative as they connect the dots, often in intense and unexpected ways.

Their similarities, along with their shared love of unconventional thinking, give Debaters and Diplomats plenty of opportunities to combine their talents on common ground. Both are statistically rare, and they're likely to recognize that they're dissimilar from most colleagues – depending on the job, as some positions attract more Intuitive people than others. However, in the average workplace, Diplomats and Debaters may find that they enjoy the uncommon conversations they have with each other, discovering a stimulating level of compatibility they don't often encounter. Although they may focus on different topics while brainstorming, they both are typically adept at producing copious novel ideas when called on to do so. They're likely to quickly identify each other as "idea people."

Complementary Perspectives

Debaters are comfortable with systems and puzzles, and they value innovation over all else. They excel at working things out, at least to the extent that they offer theories toward that end. Diplomats add to Debaters' offerings by bringing humanity to their operations. Diplomats can provide "soul" to the systems that Debaters devise or innovate. To say that Debaters are defined by a lack of humanity and that Diplomats are bereft of analytical skills, though, is an oversimplification. Rather than supplementing each other in any complete fashion, each serves to remind the other of considerations that otherwise receive lower priority. When Debaters enthusiastically push ideas forward, Diplomats can remind them that people need adjustment periods before they accept big changes. Debaters, on the other hand, can help Diplomats more easily handle any drama occurring on the job.

In the workplace, this might play out as a wholesome push and pull between the logical and the compassionate. As Debaters help their Diplomat coworkers to stay on the path of rational thought and effectiveness, Diplomats return the favor by softening blunt edges and remembering those they're doing it all for. A great product without sensitive customer service is likely to acquire a bad reputation. Then

again, what's the point of outstanding customer service if the product or service isn't viable?

Unbalanced Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

When Efficiency Hinders Support

As much as their Intuition binds them, Debaters and Diplomats still have pronounced differences. Debaters' rapid-fire ideas may not always consider how others might react – a concern that's often prominent for Diplomats. Therefore, if they settle for inflexibility and intolerance, their relationship can be problematic. Unless they seek a middle ground that honors efficiency and innovation yet also shows respect for the feelings, sensibilities, and esteem of others involved, these two may retreat to their own corners and stubbornly insist that the other is wrong.

For example, Debaters may see a project as hindered by those who are slower to accept change, believing that the best approach would be to force them to move forward or remove them from the loop entirely. Their fixation on their ideas may pull Debaters away from more sensitive plans that call for patience and allow other people time to adjust on a psychological level. On the other hand, Diplomats may spend too much time worrying about the feelings and concerns of others, bogging down progress. Cue a lot of impatience on both sides.

Blunt and Gentle Expressions

Debaters and Diplomats may also find that their outward expressions are points of contention. When dealing with people who don't see things their way, Debaters can be brusque and impatient, frustrating and disappointing Diplomats. Diplomats tend to avoid conflict, so they may disengage if their Debater detractors come across as too harsh or condescending. However, Diplomats may take a stand if they believe Debaters' attitudes are hurtful to others' feelings or welfare.

To be clear, Debaters aren't uncaring people, and their bluntness is often delivered in a spirit of support. But they rarely see the point of sugar-coating their solutions or objections just to spare others' feelings. Their version of truth or reality comes before such considerations. This

can easily create tension between them and those wearing the label of "Diplomat." As rationally intelligent as Debaters strive to be, and as social as they are, they're notorious for lacking emotional intelligence. Whereas Debaters have no problem with (or even enjoy) criticism and debate, Diplomats are acutely sensitive to contentious words and may shut down.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

Starting with Understanding

Debaters who hope to sync with Diplomats at work may want to discover what values are essential to Diplomats. Learning what motivates them can bridge an understanding gap. That doesn't mean surrendering their Debater styles or positions; rather, it draws on that which Debaters value – acquiring information to draw conclusions. To do so, however, they may need to deliberately open themselves to such information rather than assume that they already have a read on their compassionate colleagues. It's easy to stereotype those who are different – perhaps as "bleeding hearts" in this case – and to go no further in understanding them.

It may be easier for Debaters and Diplomats to connect at work if they remember that they both want to make a difference. Their motivations, methods, and desired results may be dissimilar, but they share the intention of making things better. Once they identify that common ground, they can explore the details with the essential journalistic questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. The answers may help them reach a deeper level of appreciation of each other's opinions and ideas. It's OK to disagree; in fact, with their diverse styles, Debaters and Diplomats may work together best if they agree to disagree on some issues. But that shouldn't excuse either from making attempts to understand the other with the goal of having a better working relationship.

Those who are interested in better understanding can try a five-minute time-out from judgment. Debaters can perform the following simple approach to gaining insight on their own (without necessarily discussing it with their Diplomat coworkers), or they may ask Diplomats to be entirely in on it:

- The goal is simple: non-judgmental data collection.
- Pick a mutual work topic to ask questions about.
- Establish a short period of time when you will suspend judgment (e.g., five minutes).
- Statements aren't allowed, nor are questions that make your Diplomat coworker defend their positions. For example, "Do you really think that's the right approach?" is a forbidden question. Think like a non-interfering anthropologist or sociologist who is trying to collect information without influencing the direction of the native population. Or perhaps take on the persona of an objective journalist.
- Borrow heavily from the journalistic questions and fire away.
- After time is up, take a moment to write a nonjudgmental paragraph describing the Diplomat's positions to memorialize them as more than just passing thoughts. If the Diplomat is in on the exercise, perhaps ask them to review the description for accuracy.

Those who pursue the five-minute time-out from judgment may experience two things. First, they may gain a focused, better, and purer understanding of their coworkers' opinions or ideas, free from interpretation and their own filters. Therefore, any arguments and disagreements can be based on a more complete understanding. Second, they may feel they've been heard and that their ideas are valued, which can strengthen working relationships.

Learning the Language of Diplomacy

Debaters can't change the nature of their more sensitive coworkers, but they may do themselves and their organizations a service by accepting that Diplomats' sensitivity has value even in the most impersonal workplaces. Furthermore, learning to soften their sometimes-blunt speech can go a long way toward supporting coworkers who bring a more human element to the table. The absence of such people would severely diminish human resources departments and customer service – just two of the many areas that would be impacted negatively by a world without Diplomats.

Debaters who learn to put a social buffer around their starker offerings can take giant steps toward simpatico work relationships. A car may need time to warm up on a cold morning; similarly, conversations sometimes need a friendly connection before getting down to brass tacks. When Debaters show more social grace and positivity to Diplomat colleagues, rather than challenges or contention, over time they usually see a blossoming of productive communication and cooperation. Debaters need not force warmth or platitudes, but they can tap into their own sense of curiosity to reach out to Diplomats with a basic conversation exercise:

- Greet Diplomats with a smile.
- Ask how their day is going.
- Give them a few moments to talk about themselves before replying.
- Pick some aspect of their responses and reply complimentarily. For example, if they talk about something positive they've been doing, say something like, "Wow, that's cool!" If their response is a complaint, perhaps reply, "Ugh, that really sucks!" or, "I know that must be rough for you."
- Instead of giving "me" or "I" statements, even if they're related, stay focused on what these coworkers are saying.
- After showing some interest in their day, make an excuse to move on with work. ("I've got to get back to work, but it was good to talk with you!")
- When there's a work matter to bring up, use a short version of this exercise instead of immediately launching into business.

It's essential for Debaters not to view themselves as deficient just because they don't place as much emphasis on social niceties in the workplace as others do. Their way has its merits. However, practicing skills that let them relate better to Diplomats can create the efficient communication Debaters crave. A pinch of sugar can keep ideas and facts flowing freely, getting both back to their shared creative ground.

Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

Debaters and Sentinels have fundamental differences in their intent and methods. Debaters love to experiment with the potential of a system, whereas Sentinels attend to straightforward business in the here and now, performing practical tasks and building order to support established goals. When a job suits them, Debaters and Sentinels may gravitate toward different yet complementary roles. When they marry their approaches cheerfully and respectfully, they can move mountains.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

Implementing Solutions Together

In some ways, this is a wonderful workplace match, as Debaters often need people to help them realize their visions, and Sentinels tend to act efficiently and effectively. Debaters are masters of thought but not always follow-through, so partnering with Sentinels can help them refine their ideas and yield practical results. When Debaters reveal a novel idea, Sentinels cautiously start examining the applications – and costs – in the real world, nicely balancing Debaters' often passionate embrace of the new.

Translating broader ideas into specific realities is reversible, in that such an approach can reveal solutions to more conventional problems in return. When Sentinels run up against a roadblock, Debaters may offer unconventional thinking to get things back on track. Imagination can be the tonic that cures outdated or ineffective practices used by Sentinels. The two become invaluable partners when both accept each other's unique strengths and make their unique contributions to productivity.

Future Planning

Another area of balance Debaters and Sentinels offer each other on the job is future thinking and planning. Debaters virtually live in a realm of possibility, always thinking about how to craft the future. Sentinels try to control the present, creating stability in the face of the unknown. They make plans mostly in the context of how they can act in the present to bring about security. When Debaters share their own forward-looking views, Sentinels see more possibilities than they might on their own, and together they can make mutually agreeable plans.

Debaters often bounce from idea to idea, their attention scattered between enthusiasm and curiosity. Their Sentinel coworkers can help them slow down and channel their creative energy in workable, focused directions. Cooperation between the two enables Debaters to picture smart shortcuts and spot hidden obstacles, while Sentinels plot the course of action. When Debaters' imaginative vision shapes the plans made operational by Sentinels, the workplace benefits from the best of both worlds: innovation and consistency.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

The Possibility Gap

Unfortunately, the ways Debaters and Sentinels balance each other's tendencies also have darker potential. Their profound differences can cause conflict if they don't consciously recognize each other's virtues and accept the value of cooperation. Debaters may be quick to criticize their Sentinel coworkers' ways when the Sentinels cling to methods and ideas that the Debaters feel are outdated. It's not necessarily out of malice; rather, rationality dominates Debaters' perspective, and their strident nature doesn't always leave room for tact when they express themselves.

One of the most likely breakdowns involves Debaters' love of theorizing. Their constant curiosity over "what ifs" can seem like wasted time to Sentinels, who may struggle to distinguish when Debaters are engaged in a mental exercise and when they're seriously offering a solution. If Sentinels shoot down inspired notions as "impractical" or "impossible," Debaters may take it as a personal affront. In turn, Debaters may view

Sentinels as stubborn detractors, something they don't easily ignore. When Debaters resent Sentinels' staid thinking, and when Sentinels dismiss Debaters' ambitions as unreasonable, the tension can make them lose sight of the good they could otherwise do together.

Change versus Convention

Debaters love change and constantly seek new ideas and areas for improvement. On some level, they crave change, as it represents growth and possibilities to them. Sentinels' combination of the Observant and Judging traits leads them to focus on proven standards and conventions, so they like to work with established ideas and methods. Although it would be too sweeping to say they're entirely averse to change, they're perhaps the type least comfortable with it, and a lot depends on the pace and scale of the change.

Although their differences can help to balance Debaters and Sentinels, they can just as easily lead to tension and hostility, hindering productivity. Inflexibility and ignorance of the other person's motives – which both are sometimes guilty of – can lead group efforts astray. Debaters may push too hard against what they see as illogical worship of structure and consistency; to these visionary people, overemphasis on time-worn organization and consistency is merely a hindrance. And for their part, Sentinels may see discrediting norms as a threat to the order on which they rely. When each defends their own interests, antagonistic relationships can develop, which is never helpful in the workplace.

Rebalancing Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

The Proof in the Pudding

Debaters may never get Sentinels to match their own imaginative thinking, but that isn't the only way to find balance. Debaters should understand that Sentinels aren't as impressed by theory as they are demonstration – they want something to "take to the bank." Results earn the cooperation of Sentinels. Debaters who prove their ideas through action gain credibility, which often garners them future support. Although turning their ideas into deeds may be a challenge

for these theoreticians, it's an almost inescapable challenge in the workplace, but it is well worth trying to meet. With most people, a good concrete example can far outweigh a barrage of abstract words almost every time.

Sentinels appreciate predictability, so when Debaters build a track record of successful ideas, they also earn the right to ask for a reasonable leap of faith now and then. Sentinels are generally risk-averse. But past events factor heavily into their judgment, and respected Debaters can draw Sentinels beyond their boundaries by reassuringly pointing to reinforcing examples along the way.

When Debaters are sharing ideas with Sentinels, a simple presentation exercise can help.

- Describe the goal – the value of making the change, as well as what success looks like.
- Highlight the specific benefits, possible risks, and how pitfalls can be mitigated.
- Outline the steps clearly – what it takes in real terms of human effort, training, funding, and time.
- Cite similar ideas that were successful in the past. Focus on the positive outcomes that were achieved, like higher sales numbers or increased efficiency, and how risks were addressed or proven to be unfounded.
- Maintain the congenial, respectful tone of responsible peers planning together.
- Take ownership of the idea by offering to lead in implementing it, and then create the proof of benefit.

Debaters may not enjoy feeling like they must defend their imaginations, but the reality of many workplaces is that visionary thinkers often must do just that. However, professional success is far more likely to come when they gain the support of those with a more conventional outlook, and it's strategically worth the effort.

One Step at a Time

Change, especially when based on ambitious theories and ideas, can make Sentinels uncomfortable. Debaters who are aware of their Sentinel coworkers' concerns can find more support when they link their ideas and theories to practical, specific tasks. When suggesting changes to a system, such as a company's hiring process, Debaters who bring forward ideas based on modern hiring theories may be met with skepticism from Sentinel coworkers. But highlighting specific, practical tasks (for example, changes to the interviewing process and staff training procedures for those involved in the new process) increases Debaters' odds of garnering favor with Sentinels.

Allowing plenty of time for change to take place – an opportunity for people to verify and appreciate the benefits of each stage – can also build support from Sentinels. Vocal impatience from overeager Debaters may bring out stubborn resistance from even the most supportive Sentinels if they feel that too many things are changing too quickly. To remedy this, Debaters can focus on remaining calm and focused – suggesting smaller, specific changes, then sequentially reshaping things in stages, even when the overall combined effect is significant.

- Break more substantial changes into smaller parts with verifiable short-term targets. (For instance, instead of redesigning an entire retail department, alter just a few displays.)
- Complete each change only for the sake of its own merits.
- Track the results. (Those display changes boosted sales – or not.)
- Be willing to admit when something doesn't work.
- Create a plan to undo and learn from flops. After all, knowing what didn't work and why enables better ideas in the future.
- Roll successes forward into additional, related suggestions to subtly create ongoing progress. (Perhaps expand similar merchandising changes into other areas, too.)
- Incorporate Sentinels' feedback in each stage – they may very well uncover practical issues, and Debaters can use the information to improve a process or project.

- Emphasize the teamwork involved and the value of making productive changes together: “Look what we accomplished!”

Sensible change is a good thing in business, and Debaters can work toward such change while respecting Sentinels as they provide the “sensible” pieces of the puzzle. When change is paced and balanced between innovation and proven standards, coworkers can maintain reliability without losing all-important progress.

Debater-Explorer Cooperation

On the surface, Debaters and Explorers may seem to have little in common, but the truth is more complicated. Yes, Debaters enjoy theorizing about ideas and solutions, whereas Explorers would rather do things through hands-on engagement without incessantly pondering and playing with intangible ideas. The former is motivated by expansive rationality and the latter by a constant search for novelty, experiences, and impromptu solutions. However, they share an adaptive outlook on things, which gives them a lot of ways to collaborate. When a new problem defies old solutions, both can shift their perspectives quickly.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Combining Vision with Action

Debaters and Explorers can create excellent working relationships when they tap into each other’s strengths. They often work well in a two-stage process: Debaters generating new ideas, and Explorers boosting their combined impetus to get to work. Debaters don’t always jump into motion, partly because they’re more comfortable with theory, but

their slower action is more than balanced by Explorers' bias toward action. The two may fall into sync quickly, with Debaters' imaginations excited by Explorers' readiness to engage.

"What if" can be a powerful bond when these two work together. When an idea appeals to both, the chance to discover what might be is an irresistible lure that makes things happen. Debaters revel in potentials but often find the earthy "give it a go" attitude of Explorer coworkers a very refreshing step into reality – it calls for functional experimentation with little restriction. Intellectual energy fuels tangible output when these two take on projects in a balanced way together.

Discovery Unleashed

Due to their shared Prospecting trait, Debaters and Explorers usually don't feel bound by convention. Neither may even give much thought to it. Whether experimenting with a new budget strategy or introducing a new series of entrées on a restaurant menu, these mentally flexible people leave no stone unturned in their pursuit of better outcomes. Debaters see potential everywhere, and Explorers gladly try out exciting ideas regardless of whether they're theirs or someone else's, making this team adept at opening new and sometimes unexpected doors.

Their willingness to innovate and engage new practices can be profoundly beneficial, especially when they're part of a larger team with other qualities blended in. Their genuine sense of curiosity not only creates options for the future but also inspires contagious energy in their professional environments. The new ideas and methods that Debaters and Explorers brew together can be a refreshing concoction for any business, updating old practices that may have taken hold.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Impractical Meets Impulsive

Although Debaters and Explorers can work together well, the combination does face potential problems. Explorers' focus on the present may chafe Debaters, who may see such matters as mundane. Debaters sometimes dismiss out of hand people who deal in applied solutions, out of a preference for more visionary ideas. They usually do

so by explaining why the status quo is inferior to the ideas they hold. When they voice their disdain as direct criticism, communication can quickly shut down.

If Debaters' way of thinking is too vague and impractical for too long, Explorers may see them as unrealistic, unintelligible, and disengaged from "real life" in any practical way. Explorers aren't known for impulse control, so when their frustration builds, they may suddenly lose patience. That might mean dismissing Debaters, withdrawing support, or just criticizing them outright. When the two become unhappy with each other, Debaters may resort to arrogance, and Explorers typically move forward however they see fit, ignoring Debaters as necessary. Dysfunction naturally ensues.

A Pair of Wanderers

Debaters often meander in the vastness of their own minds, and Explorers frequently get sidetracked in the experiences of the moment; both are highly distractible, so when they work together, getting off-target is a real possibility. Without some oversight, they may do each other a disservice when their shared curiosity gets out of balance. They risk sharing exciting – but not necessarily productive – things together. In most job roles, such tangential behavior causes performance to suffer and potentially gets employees into trouble.

What makes this worrisome is that neither is likely to have the skills to pull themselves back into focus. They may subconsciously lead each other into immature irresponsibility, as Debaters' unbridled creativity can become enthusiastic, experimental floundering, and Explorers may fall victim to short-sighted, spontaneous decision-making. Without something to inspire consistency, they may find themselves starting much and finishing little.

Rebalancing Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Respecting Different Types of Genius

Genius comes in many forms, and it's crucial for Debaters to appreciate Explorers' preference for hands-on execution. Even though Explorers' focus on practical matters in the moment may seem limited, success

can hinge on their attention to the finer points. Debaters should understand that Explorers are great at concrete problem-solving and responding flexibly enough to meet challenges as "boots on the ground" without many preconceptions. This nicely balances Debaters' tendency to overvalue – and thus overemphasize – their abstract ideas and visions of the future.

To understand Explorers' hands-on approach in more positive ways, Debaters can put their own hands into the mix. Participating not just in Explorers' projects but also in their methods and ways of thinking can help Debaters understand the value of other approaches. Explorers are incredibly independent, so Debaters may need to avoid monitoring or judging them by their own standards. If approached in the right spirit and tone, such learning can enable cooperation, as well as increase Debaters' knowledge with revelatory new insights – something they can't get enough of. Debaters can engage such opportunities with little planning by trying this exercise.

- Watch for opportunities to step in and offer help as a collaborative equal.
- Get to know the Explorer's workflow and methods. Adopt a novice's rather than an expert's perspective.
- Ask for demonstrations – the chance to teach a willing student can enthuse anyone.
- Try out their suggestions and practices, under their direction.
- Respect what works, even if it's a different way of doing things.

Both Debaters and Explorers focus on efficiency, just in different ways – one wrangling concepts within their minds and defending them when necessary, the other manipulating the tangible with an eye toward results. Both can better address any problems by understanding the valuable qualities that each brings to the table and knowing that cooperation is a decision.

Guiding Each Other in the Right Direction

To get their wandering attention and enthusiastic distraction under control, Debaters and Explorers can help each other attend to tasks at

hand. Multitasking is often required in today's complex workplace, but people vulnerable to losing focus may need to find ways to deliberately narrow their concentration so as not to get swept away by tangents.

By following a chosen framework together (such as the one below), Debaters and Explorers may also be able to prevent any supervisory crackdown that would hamper them – taking personal steps toward discipline may help them preserve their autonomy. However, while finding their own answers to distractibility, Debaters may need to be sensitive to Explorers' need for independence, perhaps offering suggestions broadly and with an eye toward flexibility. It may be better to use the principles below as a group standard rather than as a standard to be adopted by only certain people, to take pressure off reluctant Explorers. Tailoring a bespoke system to suit their job tasks is up to the parties involved, but some methods to consider can include the following.

- Sequential conditionality: The start of a new venture depends on completing a previous commitment. If you don't have too many balls in the air at once, you will be less likely to drop one.
- Supportive oversight: Not being left to your own devices can help you curtail constant distraction. If you cheerfully – and briefly – help each other stay focused, even individual tasks can feel like a team effort.
- Mutual assistance: Cement a positive working relationship by backing each other when you've gotten off course. It's important that this doesn't become one-sided, however – only if both individuals contribute equally will both remain willing to lend their efforts when needed. "Mutual" is the keyword.
- Accountability: Debaters and Explorers likely need external oversight to keep them accountable for their progress. So, commit to completion times and goals, and report to a third party. Management often provides this naturally, but easily distracted workers might also benefit from more casual peer accountability or cooperative project management arrangements where standards are enforced. (The latter technique is likely to be the least favorite or least sustainable for Debaters and Explorers – but it may still be worth considering.)

Whatever plan these two come up with to boost each other's dedication and focus works best when it's specific and straightforward, therefore easier to stick to. Neither Debaters nor Explorers enjoy rigid structure, but they likely need some degree of systemic organization and accountability to keep them on track and to lead them to practical results.

Conclusion

Nineteenth-century American journalist Charles A. Dana said, "Fight for your opinions, but don't believe that they contain the whole truth, or the only truth." A common difficulty for Debaters in the workplace – and in life – involves cherishing their own perspective a bit too much. As Dana asserted, there's nothing wrong with defending their opinions if they understand the limits of their own thinking and perspective.

This unique type has much to offer any enterprise. Debaters lean toward innovation and original thought. Imaginative and curious, they're passionate about their interests and ideas – at least when those views are on their front burners. If they can keep their occasionally contentious attitudes in check, they can be quite charismatic and social assets in any workplace. Allowed to run wild and unfettered, they can be difficult to work with, making success elusive. But if they can harness their strengths, they have many skills and talents to offer.

Debaters' greatest work challenge may be to find ways to balance the unique beauty and wonder of their impressive creativity so that it's more in sync with a practical world that typically demands something different. It's well within their ability – and may simply be a matter of awareness and will.

Final Words

Healthy Personal Motivation

There's no denying that aside from all the other benefits to be found in educational institutions and the workplace, personal gain is a significant factor. Debaters may be more willing than many other personality types to admit that, and that's not a bad thing. Beyond just eventual financial gains, being successful in academics and work can create a sense of purpose in life, as if one's actions (and all that time and energy spent) are connected to deeper development. Whatever definition of personal gain rings true for them, Debaters can take pride in enriching themselves and their lives with value and meaning. Striving for and fairly earning life's rewards should be a source of excitement and self-respect.

We've asked Debaters to consider many approaches to work and school that may not be natural or comfortable for them, and that invitation might raise some eyebrows. It's not unreasonable that it might even provoke the question, "What's in it for me?" Evolving one's innate habits and preferences isn't usually an easy or rapid practice, so it requires some solid, enduring motivations. For Debaters, the ultimate personal gains of success in their education and career can serve as a good reason to expand their own attitudes and approaches. The purpose of this e-book is not to ask Debaters to adopt a set of goals that don't appeal to them, but rather to better equip them to reach the goals that they seek for themselves. Trying one's best to be one's best is noble, and there's little point in shackling perfectly natural self-interest when it can serve as such excellent motivation to grow. And, perhaps, self-interest can also beckon Debaters to master different, less familiar ways to achieve success.

Embracing a Feisty Spirit

Just as Debaters prosper and grow best when pursuing goals that truly appeal to them, so must they honor their own personality along the road to success. We've highlighted many ideas that can help Debaters succeed in school and work by forging positive relationships with others and finding harmonious ways to express their personality traits. And yet Debaters can also maintain room for their adversarial spark, in appropriate contexts. Some of the greatest achievements come not through harmony but through passion and struggle, and there's a difference between being adversarial and being disrespectful.

As important as it is for Debaters to practice channeling their fiery, inspired nature in socially productive ways, expressing their personal truth is also part of how they achieve success.

As they move forward in life, Debaters can keep in mind that when it comes to speaking spiritedly, timing and tenor are key. One of the greatest reasons for Debaters to work on creating strong, cooperative bonds in school and the workplace is to preserve their ability to express themselves with minimal censorship. Where mere acquaintances or associates might balk at Debaters' unfiltered thoughts, people with whom trust and fondness flow freely are likely to be more tolerant, attentive, and receptive. School and the workplace tend to be environments with specific rules for behavior, whether casually unspoken or carefully codified. Some initial care to temper their feisty spirit can grant Debaters the freedom to be themselves, and that can help their creativity and motivation – critical elements of Debater success – flourish.

Throughout this e-book, we've emphasized how Debaters can adapt to the needs of others and take advantage of opportunities, and now we'd like to close with an affirmation of their core selves. Debaters' fire is meant to burn bright, despite the attendant risk that other people may feel singed by this personality's bold style of self-expression. But the name "Debaters" was not chosen lightly. Some degree of conflict, whether they've instigated it or merely witnessed it, serves to fuel people with this personality type. To give up that spark is not in their best interests, though of course, they greatly benefit from improving how they control and direct it. Ultimately, Debaters' success comes from their passion, and that includes accepting and appreciating their own blazing nature.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want to kick-start your career or get better at navigating it? Explore our Career Specialized Tests.
- Looking to set a foundation for learning and developing as a person? Check out the *Debater Guide to Personal Growth*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Debater Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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